song, ‘Darling, Je Vous Aime Beaucoup’, is a song that Ratan can hum at will.

As Shireen recalls, Ratan’s father gave him the moniker of ‘patriarch’ as he was always formally dressed and had a ‘serious’ air about him. One day Ratan strode in from office in his dark formal suit with an unmistakable air of confidence and authority. Seeing his son walk in, Naval spontaneously remarked, ‘Here comes the patriarch.’ The sisters had a good laugh at his expense, exclaims Shireen.

Ratan was his mother’s favourite, and the sisters were aware of this. They love their brother no end, are very proud of his achievements and are his confidantes. They are a closely knit family with strong bonds, taking delight in the lighter moments of life. His sisters used to look forward to outings with him: visits to bookstores, the movies and concerts. They recall their frequent stops at bookstores and how Ratan would ‘open their horizons’ to a ‘whole wide world’. They would attend jazz concerts, plays and dramas together. Thus, Ratan found a way to fill the vacuum which his grandmother’s passing had left in him.

Trying to Settle Down

In the early 1970s Ratan again found love with a Parsi girl. He even slipped a solitaire on her finger in a private ceremony. But the relationship did not last another two years. Ratan felt that for a host of reasons, she was not right for him.

In 1974, at the age of thirty-seven, when Ratan was at Harvard for a management course, he met an American lady at her father’s house and fell in love once again. He moved in with her as well. But this too could not last. ‘We were talking about it [marriage] and then I went back to India. She came here and stayed here with me for a couple of weeks. We went to Goa; we went to Delhi,’ he remembers. But then came the all-important question —where would they settle down? That was difficult to resolve. ‘The difficulty was that she didn’t want to leave the US,’ Ratan says. ‘If we got married, I would have to find a job for myself in the US, which I wasn’t ready to do,’ Ratan says. He was convinced that it would be unwise to migrate to the US after having invested nearly twelve years in the Tata Group. So the relationship died a natural death.